

financial worries, which led him to take a menial post in the civil service. He was also broken-hearted following his mother's death in 1865 and began drinking heavily, sparking the terrible alcoholism that was to darken his later years.

Mussorgsky's major works date from the late 1860s. *Night on the Bare Mountain*, his most important orchestral piece, was produced in 1867, and the initial version of *Boris Godunov*, his only completed opera, was finished two years later. Neither produced the reaction he had hoped for. The committee of the Imperial Theater, for example, was baffled by the revolutionary structure of his opera, which had no prima donna, no ballet elements, no conventional arias, and a series of tableaux rather than continuous action.

Mussorgsky produced a radically revised version of *Boris* in 1874, but this, too, met with a lukewarm response—not just from the critics but also, crucially, from fellow musicians. Mussorgsky's limited musical training gave his music a rough, unpolished quality that jarred with his contemporaries. Greatly discouraged by these setbacks, the composer became a chronic alcoholic, ending his days in a military hospital.

Most of Mussorgsky's music first became known in "smoothed-out" versions by well-meaning colleagues, including Rimsky-Korsakov. It was only in the 20th century, when these recensions were stripped away, that audiences were able to appreciate the raw, earthy genius of his work.